

9Marks, Mark Dever, Tim Challies, and catholicity

Two ministries have picked up the same old word.

This page explains what each one means by it, lays the two meanings side by side, and measures both against the first thousand years of the Church.

That they all may be one, that the world may believe. (John 17:21)

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What is 9Marks?

9Marks is a ministry that grew up around Mark Dever, the pastor of Capitol Hill Baptist Church in Washington and now the ministry's president emeritus. It is led today by Jonathan Leeman, its president. Its whole purpose is church health, and it names nine marks of a healthy church, in the list its own pages carry today: expository preaching, gospel doctrine, conversion and evangelism, church membership, church discipline, discipleship and growth, church leadership, prayer, and missions. Tim Challies, the most read Reformed blogger of his generation, introduced 9Marks to a wide audience in 2004 and has been its friendly popularizer ever since.

Credit belongs first, because a great deal is owed. In an evangelical world of church-growth technique and celebrity pulpits, 9Marks has spent decades teaching that a church is a defined people and not an audience, that membership means something, that discipline is love, and that the pulpit exists to say what the text says. Every one of those instincts is ancient, and the earliest documents of the Church bear them out. These churches also recite the Nicene Creed of 381 and confess one holy catholic and apostolic church, and they mean it. And in 2023 the ministry devoted an entire issue of its journal to catholicity, a word most evangelical pastors never use. Its editor called the effort a reclamation project. That project is worth taking seriously, which is what this page does.

What does this site argue?

A reader arriving here from 9Marks deserves the other half of the comparison in plain words, so here it is. This site defends a book, *Mere Catholicity*, which argues one thing: the whole Church of the first thousand years, before the East-West schism of 1054 and centuries before the Reformation, shared one faith, and that shared faith is the ground on which divided Christians could be visibly reunited. The book measures every church, Rome included, by what the whole Church received in those centuries, and it asks Rome to set down the things she later defined alone, just as it asks Protestant churches to pick up the things the whole Church always held.

What did the whole Church hold? The site's charting papers measure every communion against nine of those shared things, and they are worth listing plainly, because this page will refer to them: the Holy Scriptures, the Nicene Creed, the christology of the seven ecumenical councils, Mary as Theotokos, meaning Mother of God, the veneration of the holy icons, the apostolic succession of an ordered ministry, the real presence of Christ in the Eucharist, the regeneration given in Baptism, and the moral consensus of the early Church's teachers on life, marriage, and holy orders. Each one is documented from the first millennium's own writings, and each chart grades each church only from that church's own official standards. That is the method: no church is measured by rumor, and every claim carries a receipt.

What does the word catholic actually mean?

The word is Greek. Kata means according to, holos means the whole, so katholikos means according to the whole. It does not mean Roman, and it did not start as anyone's brand name. When Christians in the Creed confess one holy catholic church, they are confessing that the Church is one whole thing across the earth and across the centuries, not a collection of unrelated local start-ups.

Around the year 434, a monk named Vincent wrote down the test the early Church already lived by: the catholic faith is what has been believed everywhere, always, and by all. Three words, three tests. Everywhere rules out local customs. Always rules out recent inventions. By all rules out the pet positions of parties and individual teachers, however brilliant. What survives all three tests is the catholic core, and the first millennium's churches used the word exactly that way, as a boundary marker. Mark Dever's own essay on the subject, the most historically careful piece in the 9Marks journal, says this plainly: from the second or third century until the modern period, the word catholic was a term used for exclusion and definition, marking the regular from the irregular. On the meaning of the word, in other words, there is no dispute between that essay and this site. The dispute begins with what happened next.

What does 9Marks mean by it?

Jonathan Leeman, the ministry's president, gives the short version in three words: churches partnering together. He adds, fairly, that the three words take a few shortcuts and that the doctrine needs a fuller definition, and his longer essay supplies one. It is worth quoting carefully, because the whole difference between the two meanings of catholicity lives inside it.

Leeman writes that the local gathering is what we behold with the eyes of flesh, a manifestation or outpost of something we can only behold with the eyes of faith, namely, the catholic or universal church. Notice what that sentence does. The whole, the holos the word points at, is defined as invisible. The only church anyone can see is the local congregation. The universal church is real, but it can only be believed in, never looked at. And once that is the definition, the practical duty follows naturally, and Leeman states it: churches should recognize and partner with other gospel-preaching churches as occasion allows. Partnership means prayer for other churches, pulpit swaps, joint missions, sending members who move to like-minded congregations, and speaking well of one another, the program Mark Dever lays out warmly in his charge to pastors. Leeman also states, as doctrine, where the basis of all this lies: a right doctrine of catholicity, he writes, is Protestant. It roots in a shared view of the gospel, not in a shared view of the ordinances or church structure.

Dever's historical essay explains how this definition came about, and his account is candid. Luther and Calvin, he reports, gave primacy to the always in Vincent's three tests, not to the everywhere and the by all. They redefined catholic as a category about time rather than space, continuity with the apostles' teaching rather than the visible extension of one fellowship, so that catholicity among Protestants, Dever concludes, has seemed very much like apostolicity. That is an honest summary, and it can be restated without unfairness: of Vincent's three tests, this tradition kept one.

The two questions

Every definition is an answer to some question, so the clearest way to compare the two definitions is to name the two questions behind them.

The question 9Marks asks is this: given that gospel-preaching congregations are separate, and will remain separate, how should they recognize one another and work together without compromising their convictions? It is a real question, asked in good faith, and the ministry answers it well on its own terms.

The question this site asks is this: the Lord prayed that his people would be one so that the world may believe, and for a thousand years the Church visibly was one, so what would it cost each church, by name, to be one again? Also a real question.

Notice the difference in what each question assumes. The first treats the divisions between churches as a permanent condition, like weather, under which love must operate. The second treats the divisions as wounds, and asks which of them the whole Church ever agreed to, and what closing them would take. The first question produces guidance for cooperation among churches that stay separate. The second produces a survey of the separations themselves. Neither question is dishonest. But they are different questions, and the word catholicity, in its original use, belonged to the second one.

The two meanings, side by side

Here is the whole comparison in one table. The left column is 9Marks, from its own essays. The right column is the practice of the first-millennium Church, from its own documents, the receipts for which are collected on this site.

	9Marks	The first millennium
The question asked	How should separate gospel-preaching churches recognize and work with one another?	What has the whole Church received, and how is her visible communion kept and restored?
What catholic means	The universal gathering of all believers, beheld only by faith. Local churches are its visible outposts.	According to the whole: one visible fellowship of churches across the world, holding one faith, one Baptism, one Supper, one ordered ministry.

	9Marks	The first millennium
What can be seen	The local congregation.	The whole communion: one altar in each city, bishops known to one another by letter, councils gathered from East and West.
What it requires	Agreement on the gospel, plus partnership as occasion allows. Not a shared view of the ordinances or church structure.	The shared faith entire: creed, sacraments, ministry, morals, held everywhere, always, and by all.
Its instruments	Prayer for other churches, pulpit swaps, joint sending, speaking well of one another.	All of those, and also the synod, the letter of communion, the shared Supper, the common creed.
What division is	A standing condition to be navigated charitably.	A wound in the Body, to be healed.

The table is the analysis. Everything below it is detail. The short version: the first millennium had everything 9Marks commends, the prayer, the mutual help, the recognition, and it had four more instruments on top, and those four are exactly what made its unity something the world could see.

The marks, side by side

The same comparison can be run on the marks themselves, and it only takes one small table. Three lists of marks exist in this conversation. The Creed of 381 gives the Church four. The Reformation gave the true church three. 9Marks gives the healthy church nine.

The Creed's four (381)	The Reformation's three	The current nine (9Marks)
One Holy Catholic Apostolic	The word rightly preached The sacraments rightly administered Discipline exercised	Expositional preaching Gospel doctrine Conversion and evangelism Church membership Church discipline Discipleship and growth Church leadership Prayer Missions

Now count. None of the Creed's four marks appears among the nine. Unity is not a mark of a healthy church. Catholicity is not a mark of a healthy church, in the ministry named for the marks. And of the Reformation's three, the nine keep the preaching and the discipline and drop the sacraments. This absence was noticed at the very beginning by the movement's own friend. Tim Challies, in the 2004 post that introduced 9Marks to his readers, laid the nine as they then stood beside the Reformation's three and wrote plainly: glaringly absent, then, is the emphasis on the proper administration of the sacraments. He recorded Dever's answer, that most churches still place sufficient emphasis on the sacraments, so it is not a lost mark in need of recovery, and then gently disagreed, observing that the Supper in evangelical churches is thinned, deferred, and sometimes removed from the service entirely. Twenty years later the nine have been revised, prayer and missions added, and the Supper still did not make the list. That is not a gotcha. It is simply a fact about the list, and Challies saw it first.

The rail test

Definitions meet reality at the communion rail, and the journal, to its credit, does not hide this. Leeman opens his longest essay with a story against himself. Visiting a Missouri Synod Lutheran church, he read in the bulletin that he could not receive the Supper there, because that church admits to the Supper only those who share its doctrine of the Supper. He did not protest, and he explains why with real candor: his own church draws a similar line at a different place. Cheverly Baptist Church requires believer's baptism for membership, and it does not count the baptism of infants as baptism, so a Presbyterian elder, baptized in infancy and gray in the service of Christ, cannot join without being baptized again. Leeman is careful here, and the care deserves reporting: his church practices what both traditions call close communion, welcoming

to the Supper the baptized members in good standing of other gospel-preaching churches. But the welcome runs on each church's own count of who is baptized, and by his church's count the Presbyterian's christening did not happen. So the Presbyterian stands at Cheverly's rail roughly as Leeman stood at the Lutheran one, welcome in principle, fenced in fact.

The point here is not that anyone is being insincere. Every one of these churches is following its own convictions, and the essay makes a careful case that convictions and catholicity can coexist. The point is simpler. Here is a catholicity in which the partner churches cannot agree on who has been baptized, and in which the Supper, the sign of unity, is fenced by the disagreement. This site applies one rule to every church it examines, and it said of Rome's closed altar that the cost is an argument for healing the division, not for pretending it is healed. The same sentence applies here, to churches this site regards as brothers. The ache Leeman felt at the Lutheran rail was the right response. The first-millennium question is what it would take for nobody to feel it again, not because the fences were lowered carelessly, but because the churches came to agree about what stands inside them.

The walls, and Basil's letters

The journal's essay on cooperation commends a line from J.C. Ryle: keep the walls of separation as low as possible, and shake hands over them as often as you can. It is warm advice, and better than the alternative. But notice what it takes for granted. The walls stay. Lowering them and shaking hands over them is the whole program. The same essay quotes, approvingly, a judgment by Kenneth Collins and Jerry Walls that evangelical Protestantism, with all its denominational diversity, actually represents a far more impressive model of true unity than does the Church of Rome, which states the position at its clearest: the diversity of separate denominations is presented not as the problem catholicity addresses but as a kind of achievement. Another essay in the issue, discussing why a Baptist and a Presbyterian church rightly remain separate, puts it in one sentence: it's a good thing our church isn't collapsed into theirs.

Set that beside the first millennium's practice and the difference needs no sharpening. The Creed does not confess one holy friendly and apostolic church. The men who wrote the word catholic into it belonged to a Church in which the whole was a public fact, one altar in each city, bishops who carried letters of communion across the empire, councils whose decisions bound churches that had never been in the room. For them, a standing wall between churches holding one faith was not a prudence to be managed. It was an emergency.

The journal's own reach into that era shows this, and it is the gentlest exhibit on this page. Its one patristic study is a warm account of Basil of Caesarea's friendship with Eusebius of Samosata, fifteen letters of visits and prayers and very sweet honey, offered as a precedent for brotherly partnership across distance. It is a true story, and it is well told. It is also incomplete in one important way, for Basil is among the last men in the fourth century who thought friendship between churchmen was the destination. The same letter collection holds his appeals to Athanasius to take up the union of the churches as his own work, his petitions to Rome and the West begging that men be sent to knit the storm-torn churches of the East back into visible communion, and his years of labor on the schism at Antioch, one city with rival altars, which he treated not as a partnership opportunity but as a wound. Basil had the friendships. He spent them on communion. Read one letter further, and the journal's best exhibit is making this page's point.

The fear of false unity, taken seriously

There is a reason these writers keep unity at arm's length, and it deserves a fair hearing, because it is the strongest thing in their case. The journal's cautionary tale is Billy Graham, traced with receipts across four decades: the growing catholic resolve that led him to platform men who denied the atonement, and at last, in old age, to suggest that people who do not know the name of Jesus may be saved believers anyway. That story is true, and the warning drawn from it is warranted. In living memory, the word unity has done mostly one thing in American religion: dissolve doctrine. The only large-scale catholicity these men have ever seen offered is the liberal ecumenism of the mainline, unity purchased by indifference, and they have chosen truth over togetherness. Between those two options, they chose correctly.

But the first millennium is evidence that those were never the only two options. The undivided Church was not the tolerant option. She wrote the creeds, condemned the heresies by name, deposed bishops over a single word, and fenced her altar, and she did all of it as one visible body. Her unity did not dilute her doctrine. Her unity is what gave her doctrine force, because only a church that is actually one can define anything for everyone. The choice on offer from history is not between truth and togetherness. It is between a unity thinner than 9Marks, the mainline kind, and a unity considerably thicker: one that binds the creed, the sacraments, and the ministry, and not only the gospel. Reception by the whole Church, the standard the book defends at length, is the opposite of doctrinal indifference. It is doctrine with a court.

The council in Acts 15

Leeman's essay lists Acts 15 among the catholic texts, and it is one. But it repays a slower reading than it gets. In that chapter the churches face their first doctrinal crisis, and it is not settled congregation by congregation. The apostles and elders gather in one city, debate, and issue a decision, and the decision travels: as they went through the cities, they delivered them the decrees for to keep, that were ordained of the apostles and elders. Churches that were not in the room were bound by churches that were. The one full-dress example of catholicity in action inside the New Testament is a council whose decisions carried authority, and a council is the one instrument the partnership model cannot use, because in that model no church may bind another. The first millennium called the larger thing communion, and communion had organs: the synod, the letter of communion, the shared Supper, the common creed. Partnership is communion with the organs removed. The second charting paper walks through the passage, and the whole question of church order, in detail.

That the world may believe

Both 9Marks and this site build on the same prayer, John 17:21, so read the whole verse and notice its shape. That they all may be one, the Lord prays, as thou, Father, art in me, and I in thee, that they also may be one in us: that the world may believe that thou hast sent me. The prayer has a purpose clause. The oneness is for something: it is offered as evidence to the world, to people who do not yet believe. And that is the difficulty with a unity that can only be beheld with the eyes of faith. The world does not have the eyes of faith. An invisible unity cannot be evidence to anyone, by its own definition, which means it cannot do the one thing the prayer says the oneness is for. Cooperation between churches, however real, is invisible at the distance the unbelieving world stands at. What the world sees is the signage: five churches in one parking lot, each with its own statement of faith, none in communion with any other. The family tree of the divisions shows how that came to be. Communion, on the other hand, is visible from across an empire, which is how a persecuted minority of fishermen and slaves convinced pagan Rome that God had done something new in the world.

What would change

This page has compared two meanings of one word, and the comparison suggests its own conclusion, so here it is, plainly and without any demand attached, in the same spirit in which the 9Marks writers offer their counsel. Nothing in the nine marks needs to be given up. Every one of them is a recovered piece of the ancient Church's own discipline, and churches that practice them are healthier for it. What the first millennium would add is also countable. It

would add the Creed's four marks to the ministry's nine, so that a church content with permanent separation is seen as needing recovery in the same way as a church without discipline. It would seat the Supper among the marks, at the center of the first day of the week, where the earliest documents place it. It would let the partnerships already built become scaffolding for something more than partnership, the way Basil's friendships were. And it would ask the hardest habits of thought to change: to treat the divisions between gospel-preaching churches not as weather but as wounds, and to treat the faith of the first thousand years not as one tradition's property but as the common inheritance it was, the nine rows every church on these charts already shares in part.

None of that is a small ask, and this site makes the same scale of ask of Rome and the East on its front page. The reclamation of the word catholic is a good project, and it is bigger than any one ministry. The first millennium finished the sentence the nine marks begin, and the invitation of this whole site, to 9Marks as to everyone, is simply to read what the whole Church held and see whether the word does not still mean the whole. That they all may be one, that the world may believe (John 17:21).

Quod ubique, quod semper, quod ab omnibus.

Scripture quotations are from the King James Version unless otherwise noted.